

# The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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## A little extra for Opening Day



LUKE JOHNSON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The Nationals go all out with a giant American flag and a flyover before the game. Washington received a stellar start from MacKenzie Gore, who set a club record for Opening Day with 13 strikeouts and allowed one hit and no runs in six innings. But the bullpen gave up four runs in the 10th inning of a 7-3 loss to Philadelphia. **Sports, D1**

## HHS to erase 20,000 jobs, reduce offices

### NEARLY A QUARTER OF AGENCY WORKFORCE

#### RFK Jr. warns of ‘painful period’ in sweeping revamp

*This article is by Lauren Weber, Dan Diamond, Joel Achenbach, Rachel Roubein and Lena H. Sun*

The Department of Health and Human Services is cutting nearly a quarter of its workforce and consolidating several of its departments, Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. announced Thursday, a sweeping reduction of the agency that protects Americans' health, oversees Medicare and Medicaid, and ensures the safety of the nation's food and drugs. The moves will save the department about \$1.8 billion annually, the agency said in a news release, by reducing staff from 82,000 to 62,000. Half of those 20,000 employees took buyouts and early retirement, while 10,000 will lose their jobs. Kennedy's downsizing of HHS is remarkable in its scale. Virtually every corner of the HHS research and regulatory enterprise — which also includes substance

abuse, maternal health, disease surveillance and grants to research universities — is likely to be affected. With its nearly \$2 trillion budget, much of which goes to Medicare and Medicaid recipients, HHS oversees other large agencies, including the National Institutes of Health, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and the Food and Drug Administration. Kennedy announced he will reduce HHS's 28 divisions to 15 and create a new Administration for a Healthy America that includes several core functions. The number of regional offices will drop from 10 to five, and the focus will be on "safe, wholesome food, clean water, and the elimination of environmental toxins" in an effort to "Make America Healthy Again," according to the news release. In an address posted to the social media platform X, Kennedy

SEE HHS ON A7

## Judge orders agencies to preserve Signal records

BY ABIGAIL HAUSLOHNER AND OLIVIA GEORGE

A federal judge on Thursday ordered the Trump administration to preserve the records of a Signal group chat about sensitive military operations in Yemen, an incident that has sparked a firestorm in Washington. James E. Boasberg, the chief judge of the U.S. District Court in D.C., ordered the agencies rel-

evant to the case — the Defense Department, State Department, Office of the Director of National Intelligence, Central Intelligence Agency, Treasury Department and National Archives — "to preserve all Signal communications between March 11 and March 15." The defendants have until Monday to provide a "declaration regarding steps taken to implement such preservation," Boas-

berg added.

National security adviser Michael Waltz, Vice President JD Vance, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and other top national security officials earlier this month used the commercial messaging app Signal to discuss the strategy, timing, weapons and sequencing of a U.S. attack on Houthis militants in Yemen, according to a bombshell report by the Atlantic on Monday. Waltz,

who initiated the discussion, had inadvertently included the magazine's editor in chief, Jeffrey Goldberg, in the chat group. The incident has triggered outrage on Capitol Hill, where Democrats have called for investigations and for the firing of key individuals in the chat, including Waltz and Hegseth, who they say endangered American lives and national security by recklessly

SEE SIGNAL ON A4

## Document details plans to slash federal workers

### White House draft that covers 22 agencies is subject to change

BY EMILY DAVIES AND JEFF STEIN

Federal officials are preparing for agencies to cut between 8 and 50 percent of their employees as part of a Trump administration push to shrink the federal government, according to an internal White House document obtained by The Washington Post that contains closely held draft plans for reshaping the 2.3-million-person bureaucracy. The details are compiled from plans that President Donald

Trump ordered agencies to submit, according to two people familiar with the document who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to talk about it. The numbers, which have not been released to the public, show what could be next for the efforts that Trump says will make government more accountable but that have also upended agency functions and triggered restraining orders from the courts. The document covers 22 agencies and doesn't have information in some categories. Several people

SEE LAYOFFS ON A7

**A dramatic change:** Justice Dept. proposes merging ATF, DEA. **A5**  
**Smithsonian:** Trump orders purge of "anti-American ideology." **A13**

## Zelensky calms waters, but storm may lie ahead

BY LIZZIE JOHNSON AND SERHIY MORGUNOV

KYIV — The consequences of Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky's contentious White House visit last month appear to have abated. But this week's negotiations in Saudi Arabia suggest the conversation over ending the war in Ukraine will only become more difficult — and perhaps put Zelensky and President Donald Trump on a collision course yet again. Russia and Ukraine agreed Tuesday to expand a partial ceasefire to include the Black Sea, a

development that followed the resumption of U.S. military aid and intelligence sharing to Kyiv. Both the United States and Ukraine have expressed optimism in recent weeks, smoothing over the bruising Oval Office meeting where Trump and Vice President JD Vance accused Zelensky of being ungrateful and disrespectful. Yet, even in announcing an agreement, Russia and Ukraine issued separate joint statements with the United States that read

SEE UKRAINE ON A9

**A reversal:** Program tracking child abductions is reinstated. **A5**



LUDOVIC MARIN/POOL/EPA-EFE/SHUTTERSTOCK

**Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky in Paris on Thursday with Britain's Keir Starmer and France's Emmanuel Macron.**

## Trump tariffs have German workers feeling angst

BY KATE BRADY AND ANTHONY FAIOLA

ZWICKAU, GERMANY — The all-important auto industry in this east German town rolled with history's punches, surviving wars, recessions, even the division of the country as it churned out Audi racing cars in the 1920s, the boxy "Trabi" from behind the Iron Curtain and electric vehi-

cles today.

Now the people of Zwickau are bracing for a new threat: the second Trump administration. In an aggressive bid to force foreign companies to shift manufacturing to the United States, President Donald Trump on Wednesday announced tariffs of 25 percent on imported cars and auto parts, with more levies on a host of other goods set to be

unleashed April 2, the date the American leader has dubbed an economic "Liberation Day." But in Germany, an economic juggernaut whose export-led economy has been struggling, Trump's tariffs feel like the coda to an era of trade-based prosperity. The tariffs are "bad news for German carmakers, for the German economy, for the E.U., but

also for the U.S.," outgoing German Economy Minister Robert Habeck said in a statement Thursday. Habeck urged the bloc to deliver a "decisive response to

SEE TARIFFS ON A12

**Japan's response:** Tokyo has few options to counter U.S. tariffs. **A12**  
**Impact on Tesla:** Competitors will suffer from auto tariffs more. **A13**

## At Veterans Crisis Line, a cry for help from staff

### Call-takers say DOGE is making their jobs even more difficult

BY TIM CRAIG

The roughly 1,100 people who pick up the phone at the Veterans Crisis Line comfort Americans who are in the midst of life's darkest moments. The Afghanistan war veteran who wakes up with nightmares and needs to talk to someone about them. The former soldier who plans to take his own life, shotgun sitting in his lap. The spouse who worries her intoxicated husband has been drinking

and is now speeding down an interstate highway. About 2,600 times each day, someone has a story for the Veterans Crisis Line. The calls to the Department of Veterans Affairs hotline always vary, both in intensity and duration. Phone operators talk callers through their problems, enlisting help from local first responders or other VA programs when warranted. But over the past six weeks, employees at the crisis line have been left reeling over President Donald Trump's cuts to the staffing and contracts of federal agencies, including VA. Now, the call-takers and their union representatives say, the employees need even more

SEE VETERANS ON A6

## IN THE NEWS

**Alleged MS-13 leader arrested** AG Pam Bondi said the suspect ran the gang's East Coast operations, but court records didn't accuse him of specific gang-related activity. **B1**  
**Seeking a more aggressive fight** A populist uprising is stirring among Democrats furious at their party's leaders. **A3**

**THE NATION**  
**A New York** clerk refused to enforce Texas's order against a doctor over abortion pills. **A2**  
**Rep. Elise Stefanik** will stay in the House instead of being ambassador to the U.N. **A5**

**THE WORLD**  
**South Korea** admitted babies were taken from families without consent for adoption overseas. **A8**  
**A budget win** gives Israel's Benjamin Netanyahu a rare period of political security. **A9**

**THE ECONOMY**  
**Investigations** by the Justice Department's recently disbanded anti-kleptocracy team had entangled presidential allies. **A11**  
**Big Oil** is ramping up its attacks on climate Superfund laws by suing environmental activists and policymakers. **A18**

**THE REGION**  
**Senators** grilled the FAA chief on warning signs missed before the deadly crash at Reagan National Airport. **B1**  
**Gov. Glenn Youngkin** fired an outspoken U-Va. Board of Visitors member after the 2022 appointee refused to resign. **B1**

**STYLE**  
**Braces**, once the object of ridicule, are becoming a fashion choice among some adults. **C1**  
**WEEKEND**  
**D.C.'s Shaw** neighborhood is full of great places to whet your appetite. We run down a list of our favorite restaurants in the area.

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